

Digital Tools | DVD Writer Test

the quietest when burning, which makes them better suited for HTPCs.

Bundled Accessories

With attempts to make optical drives dirt cheap, this is one area where all manufacturers are cutting costs, and as a result, the bundles are miserable. Samsung drives are the only drives that come with SATA and power cables, the rest expect you to buy these yourself. The ASUS DRW-1814BLT comes with two LightScribe discs, so you can try out the technology before deciding to buy any more media—which isn't exactly cheap.



Sony DRU-845S
Fancy looking

On the software front, Nero 7 Essentials is the burning software of choice for all manufacturers, while only Samsung bundles Nero Express 7. There is no separate DVD playback software bundled anymore because Nero Showtime is a part of the Nero package and can play even HD movies. Samsung's decision to bundle Nero Express 7 gets it some brownie points here because you also get Nero BackItUp (backup utility) and ReCode (video encoding) in addition to all the regulars that Nero 7 Essentials contains. Only the ASUS DRW-2014LT and the Sony DRU-845S come with extra bezels to let you change the colour of the drive to match your cabinet.

PERFORMANCE

Reading Nero CD/DVD Speed

All the drives performed well in this test and did not show any abnormal drop in read speeds during any part of the test. Most of the drives lingered around average speeds of about 12x for DVDs, but the ASUS drives underperformed with 9x. In the CD speed tests, the Moser Baer drive and Sony's DRU-190A ruled the roost with 37 MBps. The rest of the drives managed around 30 MBps. A burst rate of over 60 MBps for DVDs was typical for all the SATA drives.



Asus BC-1205PT
'Combo' is the keyword

Next-gen optical drives featuring blue lasers have been launched in India well over a year ago, but have found it hard to get a footing. The reason is the excessive price and inaccessibility of the media. Our test labs received just one Blu-ray drive last year and no HD-DVD drive. This year too, the picture did not change much. We received two Blu-ray drives—ASUS BC-1205PT and Sony BWU-2005. While the Sony can read as well as write to Blu-ray media, the ASUS is a combo drive and its capabilities are limited to only reading from such media. Nevertheless, both drives are completely backward compatible and can write DVDs as well as CDs.

Both drives sport attractive-looking black bezels with the Blu-ray logo. We found that the tray mechanisms of these drives was noticeably different from conventional DVD writers that we tested—it seemed more rugged and slid precisely and smoothly. They come with a SATA interface and feature an 8 MB buffer, necessary for smooth HD playback.

The Sony BWU-2005 can write to BD-R and BD-RE media at 4x and 2x respectively. While the Sony sports a DVD writing speed of 16x, the ASUS can do just 12x—too slow when you consider that 20x is the norm today. It



Sony BWU-2005
As expensive as a high-end PC!

took the Sony around six minutes to write to a DVD, which is par for the course, while the ASUS was understandably slower and took over seven minutes and ten seconds. In the Nero DVD Speed read test, the Sony clocked 12.29x, which is a good score, while the ASUS lagged behind with just 9.44x. Unfortunately, we could not test these with BD media—none are available.

Both these Blu-ray drives come with CyberLink BD Solution suite—a full-fledged suite of applications that consist of CD/DVD/BD burning application, HD playback software, backup tools, as well as video authoring and editing application PowerProducer. The ASUS BC-1205PT is priced at Rs 15,500, while the Sony BWU-2005 costs a whopping Rs 38,000, making both this drives out of reach of most mortals. We fail to justify the absurdly high price tag and just cannot recommend any of these. We suggest that you wait and watch as the prices are slated to plummet in the next few months.

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Philips SPD2515T
Expensive performer

SiSoft Sandra Pro Business 2007

The SiSoft Sandra file transfer index reconfirmed our previous test, with most of the drives scoring between 12 and 13 MBps, with the ASUS drives lagging with just 10 MBps.

Audio CD And DVD Ripping

Finally, one of the ASUS drives decided to put up a fight! The ASUS DRW-1814BLT was the fastest at ripping the audio CD—taking just 39 seconds—miles ahead of the rest. There was no conclusive winner in the DVD ripping test, with most drives completing the task in around a minute. The ASUS DRW-2014LT was the slowest—it took just under two minutes to rip the DVD file.

Writing Media Compatibility

We faced certain media compatibility issues with some of the drives, despite using certified media that is commonly available and popular.

As far as rewriteable media is concerned, there were no issues with any of the drives. CD-Rs did have some issues—while most drives supported 48x and recognised the 52x certified media at this (48x) speed, some such as the Sony DRU-845S and ASUS DRW-1816BLT could only recognise the media as 40x and 24x respectively.

Only the Moser Baer drive could recognise the DVD-R as 20x, while both the ASUS drives recognised it as 16x, and this affected their performances. The rest of the drives could recognise the DVD-R as 18x. When it comes to our DVD+R media, most drives correctly recognised it as 16x—except for the Moser Baer and Sony DRU-190A, which reported the media to be 18x.



Moser Baer DH-20A4P23C
Almost a winner

simply plug and play

Preventing Article 57 (1000w)
BY 1000w. The 1000w that doesn't
need a computer to get going.
New Model brings you a compact
all in one! Best copy with a
unique, built-in USB port,
saving you the annoying
cables and allowing to
your own drive and also
printing from it, without the
need of running on your
computer. Moreover, with its
small footprint and sleek
look, it is sure to make a
great impression.



Full-Speed USB 2.0/1.1/480Kbps
Print | Copy | Scan | Fax
AA size laser MP: 10 ppm
Unique port design for direct print & scan

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